

Question 14 · Unit 1 · 8 Marks

Analyse the changing role of an HRD professional as organisations move from traditional personnel administration toward strategic human resource development.

Introduction

An HRD professional is the specialist who designs and facilitates people-development systems. That role has not stayed the same. Traditional personnel administration was about files, rules, attendance, wages and arranging an occasional training class. Strategic human resource development is about building the capabilities the business will need, shaping climate, and sitting with top management as a partner. Analysis should show from-what-to-what, why the change happened, and what new skills the professional needs.

If an organisation only changes the nameplate from 'Personnel' to 'HRD' but the person still only books a hall and marks attendance, the role has not actually changed. The question asks you to analyse the real shift.

Detailed points

- 1. From record-keeper to diagnostician.** Earlier the job was to maintain service books, training attendance, leave records and standing orders. The new role starts with diagnosis: what capability gap is blocking strategy? What does the climate survey say? Is the problem skill, motivation, or a broken process? The professional must have the courage to tell management that training is not always the answer. This is analysis, not clerking.
- 2. From classroom organiser to learning architect.** Traditional work was inviting a guest speaker and printing a banner. Strategic HRD designs a mix: on-the-job coaching, e-learning, projects, mentoring, classroom. Learning is treated as a system that must transfer to behaviour. The professional designs that system, and often trains managers to teach, rather than personally teaching every course.
- 3. From isolated training cell to integrator of subsystems.** Personnel training cells lived apart from promotion and appraisal. The new role connects performance appraisal, potential appraisal, career planning, feedback, counselling and organisation development so that they share one purpose. Integration is now a core responsibility, because isolated tools do not develop people.
- 4. From the edge of the organisation to the strategy table.** Strategic HRD requires business literacy. The professional must understand customers, technology and competition enough to translate 'we will open 20 new branches' into 'we need these supervisory competencies in 18 months'. The role includes advising directors, not waiting for a department to send a training requisition slip.
- 5. Change-agent role.** Mergers, computerisation, quality drives and restructuring frighten people and make old skills useless. Personnel used to issue transfer orders. The HRD professional now facilitates change: communication, reskilling, counselling resistance, redesigning culture. This is organisation-development work.
- 6. Developer of line managers, not a substitute for them.** The notes insist HRD is every manager's job. The professional's new role is to skill bosses in appraisal discussion, feedback and coaching, and to hold them accountable. Success is measured by whether managers develop their teams, not by how many programmes the HRD cell conducted.
- 7. From activity counting to evaluation and ethics.** Old role reported '12 programmes, 400 participants'. New role uses Kirkpatrick-type evaluation, climate data and HRD audit: did behaviour and results change? Ethics also grew: confidentiality in counselling, fairness of opportunity. A professional who leaks ratings destroys climate and cannot be strategic.
- 8. Why the change happened, and the remaining tension.** Competition, liberalisation, technology and the idea of human capital forced organisations to treat people capability as strategy, not welfare. The tension is that many firms still want the old clerk with a fashionable title. Analysis should end by saying the role changes fully only

when top management gives HRD a strategic mandate and the professional builds new competencies: consulting, facilitation, business understanding, and integrity.

Conclusion. *The HRD professional's role has moved from personnel clerk and training organiser to diagnostician, learning architect, integrator, strategy partner, change agent, coach of managers, and evaluator. Write a clear before–after analysis with reasons. The title 'HRD' means little unless the work itself has become strategic.*